Commit and watch the ball.

The aim was to be able to take my pads off in the dressing room, knowing that I had followed that instruction, whether I had scored 0 or 100. For a while, I needed only to look at the back of my bat for a reminder of my priority. It carried the name of a sponsor, Clydesdale Bank. ‘C’ and ‘B’. Commit to the Ball.

In terms of temperament I wasn’t that different from the young lad who flew halfway round the world to make his Test debut against India in Nagpur in 2006, but my technique had improved. I was a better driver of the ball, left it with greater accuracy, was more confident off my legs and more capable of hitting the short ball for four. I was able to get my weight back into the ball, and my hands were a lot closer together.

We all have our hallmarks. I make two taps of the bat as I prepare to face. The bat is raised to thigh height, and then raised again. Keep the head still, the knees flexible, shoulders slightly open. Move back and across the crease, to help play off the back foot. Then it’s down to the other guy, with the ball in his hand. He’s pretty good at what he does.

I played and missed at four deliveries from Mohammed Shami, moral defeats that didn’t matter when he gave me the chance to straight drive for four. I held the follow-through, and walked forward, like a golfer reading the line of a putt into the hole. I made eye contact with the bowler, and we both smiled. The game within the game was underway.

I’d looked in all sorts of trouble, needed luck to survive, but that cameo proved the next delivery is all that matters. I suppose it also confirmed I could deal with the hullaballoo, isolate outside influences and focus on the ball coming towards me. I wasn’t in the zone golfers talk about, where events occur in slow motion and the crowd is a multichromatic blur, but I was at ease with myself.

I was 46 not out overnight, grateful that Rooty had taken most of the strike in a nervy last fifteen minutes. He wanted two from the final ball of the day, but I strolled a single. There was no way I wanted to be first up the following morning, because I didn’t want to get out to the first delivery of the day on this, of all occasions. That nigh Ian Elliott, my former partner at Maldon, passed on important news from Statto, the club’s resident numbers man. I needed four more runs to secure an average of 45, and thirty to beat Kumar Sangakkara on the all-time lists.